

These are the times we live in (I)



SUMMARY

The speaker describes handing over their passport at border control. The officer looks at their face and flips to the last page of the passport to check all the stamps. The speaker reflects that they could take offense at this, but at last feels resigned to it: it only makes sense, they say, considering the times we're living in.

The speaker feels reduced to nothing *but* their passport. They can see what the officer is thinking: *That name is suspicious, it's got a Z in it, and this address changed recently. I think this person's birthmark moved positions.* Nothing he notices about the speaker seems quite right to him. But what, the speaker reflects, can you expect? This kind of scrutiny is a sign of the times we're living in.

Right in front of the speaker's face, the officer flips to the photograph page and looks at the speaker mistrustfully.

Now the speaker feels they have to laugh. Sarcastically, they imagine that they must have changed completely while they were on the airplane: their chin must have been reshaped and their hair restyled. Someone must have erased their mouth and their eyes. Something must have transformed them.

The only thing left behind after this remodeling is the border officer's mistrustful expression, because he doesn't think the speaker matches their photograph. The photograph is collapsing. It shows the speaker's features, but it leaves out their heart.

Half of the speaker's face breaks off and floats onto a page of today's newspaper.

As it lands, it makes a rustling noise.

The poem's speaker isn't surprised when a border agent at an airport eyes them suspiciously. This behavior is par for the course in the "times we live in," they say: in other words, they've encountered exactly this kind of prejudice *plenty* of times before. (The implication is that the poem takes place around when it was published in 2006, in the wake of the September 11 terrorist attacks and the wars that followed them. In the western world, a terrible torrent of Islamophobic discrimination followed these events.)

Though this behavior is so familiar to the speaker that they don't even have it in them to be "offended" at first, it's also inhumane and plainly ridiculous. Imagining what the man might be thinking about them, the speaker "can see his mind working" on the fact that, for instance, their name "contains a Z" (that is, it isn't a standard English name) and they "just moved house"—a moment that suggests just how broad, blunt, and childish the agent's stereotypes are. Plenty of his fellow citizens don't have traditional English names, and plenty of them might have recently moved. But blinded by his prejudice, the agent can see only a *type* of person in the speaker—a type he's prejudiced against, so that he gropes for reasons not to trust them.

The situation becomes especially painful (and especially absurd) when the agent stares hard at the speaker's passport photo to judge whether they "match [their] photograph." The speaker "really ha[s] to laugh" at the agent's ludicrous suspicion: they would have to have been "made [...] over completely" on the airplane not to match their picture. Though the speaker laughs, this is also clearly a painful and humiliating experience. Under the agent's gaze, the speaker feels as if they "shrink to the size / of the book in his hand," becoming nothing *but* a passport to him. He simply refuses to see their humanity and individuality. Prejudice, the poem thus suggests, is reductive, illogical—and seriously damaging.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-39



THEMES



THE CRUELTY AND IRRATIONALITY OF DISCRIMINATION

"These are the times we live in (I)" describes a tense encounter at a border control gate. The speaker—presented in the second person as "you," so the reader is invited to stand in their shoes—faces a border agent who reads their passport, stares boldly at them, and clearly suspects them of being up to no good. All that suspicion is founded on one thing: the speaker, to the agent, appears to be Muslim, and the poem takes place in the Islamophobic political climate of the early 21st century. Such racist and Islamophobic prejudice, the poem suggests is reductive, dehumanizing, and absurd.



THE BURDEN OF PREJUDICE

At first, the poem's speaker doesn't even have it in them to be "offended" when the border agent they're confronting at an airport starts to suspiciously flip through their passport. As a person from a Muslim country in a post-9/11 world, they are all too familiar with racism and Islamophobia. That doesn't mean, however, that the experience doesn't hurt and humiliate them. Dealing with prejudice, this poem suggests, can eat away at a person's sense of self, safety, identity, and community.

Even though the speaker feels wearily familiar with the agent's behavior, they still feel terribly small and unseen as he examines them. In the eyes of this xenophobic man, the speaker "shrink[s] to the size / of the book in his hand": they feel as if they're nothing more than the nationality stamped on their passport.

The pain of this experience only worsens as the agent stares intently at the speaker's passport photo, as if the speaker's whole face might somehow have been "made [...] over completely" while they were on the airplane. The agent's suspicion here is so patently absurd that the speaker "really ha[s] to laugh." But though they laugh, they also feel wounded. In reading the speaker so suspiciously, the agent "misse[s] out [their] heart," erasing their humanity and individuality.

The speaker gets at the pain of this experience with an image of "half [their] face split[ting] away" and landing on the "page of a newspaper / that's dated today." This vision suggests that they feel a huge part of themselves going unseen—or *mis*-seen. The border agent can see them only as the kind of face that you might see on the front page of a newspaper over an article about terrorism. That reductive reading of them makes them feel *torn in half*, both injured and reduced to something less than a whole person.

The very fact that the speaker wearily accepts this pain as "a sign of the times we live in" itself suggests how burdensome it is to endure prejudice. To face a world that constantly treats you as an object of suspicion and judgment is to feel small, hurt, and unseen on a daily basis. For that matter, it means having a sadder, bleaker view of the world around you. The speaker knows that they're surrounded by people like this border agent, people who refuse to see the complete, complex human beings standing in front of them.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 4-10
- Lines 18-19
- Line 23
- Lines 33-39



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-8

*You hand over ...
... we live in.*

"These are the times we live in" is written in the second person: the protagonist here isn't an "I" or a "she," but a "you." Readers are thus invited to imagine themselves in the position of the person this poem describes—a person who is standing at airport border control in an unnamed country, "hand[ing] over [their] passport" to a suspicious officer. (For simplicity's sake,

we'll still refer to this "you" as "the speaker" in this guide.)

Even in the first couple of lines, there are hints that that this is going to be a humiliating, infuriating experience:

- Readers can tell the border agent is stereotyping and racially profiling the speaker because, after a brief "look[] at [their] face," he flips to the "last page" of their passport. In other words, one look at this speaker and the officer decides he should scrutinize their entire travel history.
- In fact, in a [metonym](#), the passport *becomes* the speaker here: the agent starts "reading **you** backwards from the last page." The agent treats the speaker's passport, in other words, as if their nationality and proof of ID is *all there is* to them.
- Readers can thus gather that this speaker must visibly belong to an ethnicity the officer has certain racist suspicions about. Perhaps the reader might guess that this experience is one that's all too familiar to Imtiaz Dharker, a Pakistani writer who emigrated to the UK as a small child.

The speaker accepts this hostile treatment with weary familiarity. "You could be offended," they reflect—but what's the point? "Given the times we live in," this kind of treatment "makes as much sense / as anything else."

That resignation to being treated poorly in a world that clearly doesn't make much sense at all helps to place this poem in time. Dharker published this poem in 2006, in the wake of the September 11th terrorist attacks, the U.S. invasion of Iraq—and a wave of intense Islamophobia and racism that meant Muslim people (and any brown-skinned person who might be ignorantly stereotyped as a Muslim) faced intense scrutiny, exclusion, and cruelty all across the Western world.

This speaker's sigh that the border official's nonsensical stereotyping "makes as much sense / as anything else" thus feels like a bigger sigh over the bewildering, tragic state of the world. Terrorism, war, clueless discrimination: it's all part of the big ugly package that makes up "the times we live in." Nothing is going well, and this personal insult is just one small corner of a nasty bigger picture.

Dharker's choice to use the second person in this poem insists that all readers step into the shoes of the person being profiled at a border, feeling the humiliation and weary resignation as their own. And the lack of further detail here—what border this is, for instance—makes it clear that this experience is not a fluke. A person who fits the stereotyped bill, whether because they come from a predominantly Muslim country (like the Pakistani Dharker) or simply because they have brown skin, might have a similar experience at any number of borders.

As well as being an all-too-real experience for a lot of people, the confrontation at the border this poem describes has a

[symbolic](#) weight. Whether or not you're allowed to cross a border might also here suggest the question of whether or not you're treated as a fellow citizen, a member of a shared society.

Dharker will explore this experience in [free verse](#), with no [rhyme scheme](#) or [meter](#). The poem's form will instead change shape to mirror the speaker's feelings as they undergo this humiliating experience. For instance, the rhythm of the lines "it makes as much sense / as anything else," with their steady pace and even length, helps to suggest the speaker's total lack of surprise at the discrimination they face.

LINES 9-15

*You shrink to ...
... arm or leg.*

Under the scrutiny of the border officer, the speaker feels as if they're "shrink[ing] to the size / of the book in his hand." All they are to this man, this [metaphor](#) suggests, is their passport—that is, their nationality, their connection to other countries, their *otherness*.

As the officer reads the passport, the speaker reads the officer. They can *tell* what he's thinking; they've seen it before. He's telling himself to "keep an eye on that name. / It contains a Z [...]." A name with a Z in it, to this man, is suspiciously foreign. (The detail of the Z in the name hints that this experience might be one that Imtiaz Dharker herself endured.)

The officer also seems uncomfortable with the idea that this speaker has "moved house" recently. In fact, he's uncomfortable with the idea of movement in general. He suspects, for instance, that the speaker's "birthmark shifted recently / to another arm or leg." Along with suggesting that this man is ludicrously paranoid, digging deep to confirm his racist suspicions, these images of suspicious *movement* [symbolically](#) hint that he's not comfortable with the idea of people who move from one place to another! Again, there's an echo of Dharker's own experience as an immigrant here.

Note the use of the pronoun "it" here, too: the officer refers to the speaker's name as "it" and then says, "it just moved house." This moment reflects how dehumanizing xenophobia and discrimination can be; the speaker is a thing rather than a human being.

LINES 16-19

*Nothing is quite ...
... we live in.*

The speaker sums up the border agent's attitude in these telling lines:

Nothing is quite the same
as it should be.

These words refer to the man's racist suspicion that the person

standing before him isn't what they claim and might be dangerous. But they also hint at the bigger fear that feeds this discrimination: that the world isn't "quite the same" as it was before the "times we live in" got so fearful, that he's been forced to face a scary and unfamiliar landscape. He's choosing to deal with this discomfort by fearing and suspecting innocent people.

Dharker uses a pointed [enjambment](#) to drive this point home. By breaking the line after the word "same" ("nothing is quite the same / as it should be") she invites readers to lean hard on that word, and thus on the idea of frightening, bewildering *change*. The officer's suspicion that the speaker's passport isn't "as it should be" reflects his sense that the *world* isn't the "same" as it once was and as he feels it "should be."

This stanza's closing lines echo the closing lines of the first. Before, the speaker observed that they weren't at all surprised to be treated this way "given the **times we live in**." Now, the stanza closes with words that could equally belong to the speaker or the border agent: "But what do you expect? / It's a sign of the **times we live in**."

This [repetition](#) again stresses a mood of hopeless resignation. Whether it's the border agent thinking that he can only expect suspicious passports from shifty foreigners, or the speaker thinking they can only expect discrimination from racist border agents, all parties involved feel unhappy, but stuck with what they've got.

The repetition of the words "the times we live in" might also suggest that this [refrain](#) has become a [cliché](#). These same words are the only response anyone can find to the depressing realities they're facing daily.

LINES 20-22

*In front of ...
... at you suspiciously.*

The third stanza is short—just three lines long—and telling. The speaker uses a series of [end-stopped lines](#) to describe the officer comparing the speaker to their passport photograph:

In front of **you**,
he flicks to the **photograph**,
and looks at you **suspiciously**.

The speaker breaks this single sentence out into three lines, all separated by natural pauses at commas. Each of these lines thus gets a little pocket of breathing space, suggesting how very *unhurried* the border agent is as he rudely compares the photo in the passport to the person standing before him. By spreading this incident out over these three spacious lines, the speaker captures the border agent's officious sense of his own importance. He has *all the time in the world* to stare rudely at this "suspicious[]" traveler—and he's not worried in the slightest about wasting *their* time.

Indeed, the speaker also highlights how insulting this obvious suspicion feels by keeping the words “in front of you” on a line by themselves. Of course, in one sense, the border agent has no choice but to compare the speaker to their passport photo “in front of” them. But by choosing these words here, the speaker makes it clear that the border agent is revealing something about himself and his suspicions in his behavior. He doesn’t even make a show of politeness; he doesn’t make the slightest effort to conceal his suspicion from the speaker.

LINES 23-30

*That's when you ...
... you over completely.*

In the fourth stanza, the dark comedy of the officious, pompous border agent’s scrutiny actually makes the speaker “laugh.” There’s something so ridiculous about the idea that the speaker might not resemble their passport photo that the speaker has to play out the scenario in their mind, imagining what would have had to happen for them to no longer match their passport. The poem starts using dense patterns of rhyme, [repetition](#), and sound here, creating an [ironically](#) jolly bounce:

While you were flying,
up in the air
they changed your chin
and redid your hair.
They scrubbed out your mouth
and rubbed out your eyes.

All these jaunty sounds—the [end rhyme](#) of “air” and “hair,” the [internal rhyme](#) of “scrubbed out” and “rubbed out,” the /ch/ [alliteration](#) of “changed your chin,” the long [assonance](#) of “while you were flying”—make this passage feel musical and cheerful. The effect highlights the speaker’s sarcastic tone.

But within the speaker’s angry joking about being “made [...] over completely” on the airplane, there’s a sad reality. When the speaker imagines a mysterious “they” who “changed your chin / and redid your hair,” they’re also hinting at the way that many of their fellow human beings *see them differently* in the “times we live in.” Their fellow people *have* changed the way they look, in a sense: they’ve changed the speaker’s features from those of an ordinary person to those of an object of suspicion.

That idea is particularly pointed in the lines “they scrubbed out your mouth / and rubbed out your eyes.” [Symbolically](#), the transformation here suggests that the speaker feels silenced and dehumanized as the border agent looks at them. They can’t speak in their defense—and the border agent doesn’t seem ready to look them in the eye and acknowledge their humanity.

LINES 31-35

*And all that's ...
... out your heart.*

Under the border agent’s dehumanizing gaze, the speaker finds that their own face has been replaced completely. “All that’s left,” they say, “is his look of surprise”: the agent’s face remains when the speaker’s face, [symbolically](#) speaking, has been erased. As the agent stares at them, the speaker gets transformed into just an object of suspicion, their every feature a potential clue to bad intentions.

Even the passport “photograph,” the speaker says, is “coming apart” into “pieces.” It is figuratively breaking up, disintegrating. And there’s something important *missing* from it as well: the speaker’s “heart” isn’t visible in the image. The speaker blames the mysterious “they” who [metaphorically](#) rearranged their features for this omission: “**They** missed out your heart,” the speaker says. This image suggests that racist and Islamophobic people like the border agent see people like the speaker as just a suspicious collection of foreign-looking features—and fail to notice, let alone honor, their humanity. The speaker’s metaphorically disintegrating passport photo here thus represents their experience of feeling separated from their true identity and ripped to shreds by discrimination.

Again, a meaningful line break and a rhyme highlight this realization:

Even that is coming *apart*.
The pieces are *there*
but they missed out your *heart*.

The rhyme between “apart” and “heart” and the dramatic pause between the image of the “pieces” and the image of the missing heart slow these lines down, asking readers to really sit with the feeling of being dehumanized, having your “heart”—your true feelings, your intentions, your selfhood—cut out of other people’s pictures of you.

LINES 36-39

*Half your face ...
... as it lands.*

The poem closes, not with any resolution to the tension between border agent and speaker, but with a strange, dreamlike vision. “Half your face,” the speaker says, “splits away.” This image that might equally refer to the passport photograph (shown [metaphorically](#) “coming apart” in the previous stanza) or to the speaker’s actual face, objectified and disintegrating under the border agent’s suspicious gaze.

This half-face blows away and lands on the “page of a newspaper / that’s dated today.” In this image, part of being dehumanized this way is being seen as a type of character that might be in the news. The border agent is clearly imagining that the speaker might be a terrorist, someone whose face he might see on the front page in the wake of some terrible crime. But it’s only *half a face*, too: the border agent simply is not seeing the speaker as a whole person.

The idea that this paper is “dated today” gets highlighted in its own line here. This choice again stresses the idea that these events are all part of the “times we live in.” It’s “today” that the agent (and people like him) are dehumanizing the speaker like this, here and now.

The final stanza consists of a single ominous line. The speaker’s half-face “rustles as it lands” on today’s newspaper, in a moment of hushed [imagery](#) that highlights the suspenseful, tense silence as the agent stares the speaker down. Readers can sense the hostility of this man as he looks at a person he’s unwilling to see as a person.

hand.”

- **Lines 21-22:** “he flicks to the photograph, / and looks at you suspiciously.”
- **Lines 31-35:** “all that’s left is his look of surprise, / because you don’t match your photograph. / Even that is coming apart. / The pieces are there / but they missed out your heart.”
- **Lines 36-39:** “Half your face splits away, / drifts on to the page of a newspaper / that’s dated today. / It rustles as it lands.”



SYMBOLS



THE PASSPORT

The speaker’s passport becomes a [symbol](#) of alienation and dehumanization. The small-minded, racist border agent in this poem treats the speaker as if they’re nothing *but* a passport. Flipping through the speaker’s travel history, to him, is “reading [the speaker],” not just reading where they’ve been: this ID document becomes the speaker’s whole identity in his hands. This treatment makes the speaker feel diminished, “shrink[ing them] to the size of the book in his hand.” Symbolically speaking, it’s as if their whole self is at the mercy of a deeply prejudiced system that simply doesn’t see them as a person.

That feeling gets all the more acute as the border agent takes a long hard look at the speaker, comparing them to their passport photo. Under this gaze, the speaker starts to feel as if they’re “coming apart.” The photo is *them*, of course. But they can also imagine it through the agent’s eyes, and to him, this photo looks like a totally different person. For the agent, this photograph looks not like a photograph of the real live person in front of him, but like the kind of photo one might see on the “page of a newspaper” under headline news about dreadful crimes.

The passport thus starts to represent the gap between how an Islamophobic world sees the speaker and how the speaker really is. The speaker feels *shredded* by the way the agent looks at them and their photograph: through his stereotyping eyes, the speaker’s “heart” simply isn’t visible. There’s a big space between who they really are and how they’re seen; the stereotypical image the agent sees in that photograph is *not who they are*.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-3:** “You hand over your passport. He / looks at your face and starts / reading you backwards from the last page.”
- **Lines 9-10:** “You shrink to the size / of the book in his



POETIC DEVICES

METAPHOR

The poem’s [metaphors](#) help to show how dehumanized the speaker feels in the face of the border agent’s suspicion. From the very first stanza, the agent reduces the speaker to their passport: as the speaker puts it, when they hand over their passport, he “starts reading [them] / backwards from the last page.” In this metaphor (which is also an example of [metonymy](#)), the speaker is their travel document to the agent: their nationality and their movements are all this guy can see about them. “You shrink to the size / of the book in his hand,” the speaker goes on, suggesting that this experience feels humiliating and diminishing.

Under the agent’s scrutiny, the speaker starts feeling divided from their own real identity, an idea they explore through the image of their passport photograph. When the agent looks dubiously between this photograph and the speaker’s face, the speaker “has to laugh” at his obvious (and racist) suspicion. But it’s a sad laugh. This photo, they reflect, “misse[s] out their heart.” In other words, the agent can’t see the speaker’s *humanity* and *feelings* as he looks at their photo. The speaker’s metaphorical heart simply isn’t visible to this man: he can’t see the speaker as a complete person.

That makes the speaker feel split in half, divided from themselves—an image the speaker makes concrete in the poem’s closing metaphor, in which “half [the speaker’s] face splits away” and “drifts on to the page of a newspaper.” Here, the speaker can see their face as the agent sees it: as the kind of face you might see on a front page, accused of terrorism. This imaginary newspaper is “dated today,” the speaker says: this perspective is just another sad sign of the “times we live in.”

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-3:** “He / looks at your face and starts / reading you backwards from the last page.”
- **Lines 9-10:** “You shrink to the size / of the book in his hand.”

- **Lines 33-35:** “Even that is coming apart. / The pieces are there / but they missed out your heart.”
- **Lines 36-39:** “Half your face splits away, / drifts on to the page of a newspaper / that's dated today. / It rustles as it lands.”

REPETITION

[Repetitions](#) help to capture the speaker's world-weary sorrow at the way the border agent treats them, and at the state of the “times we live in” more generally. In fact, those very words—the “times we live in”—form one of the poem's most prominent repetitions. The speaker closes both the first stanza and the second with variations on this [refrain](#):

- In the first stanza, they decide they don't even have the energy to be surprised or offended at the way the border agent is treating them. It's just what they can expect will happen, “given the times we live in.”
- In the second stanza, the same words appear as a sigh of resignation after the agent looks suspiciously at the speaker's face. “But what do you expect?” the speaker says: “It's a sign of the times we live in.”

This repetition suggests that the speaker has seen this kind of behavior many, many times before: it's just part of the way the world is for them these days. But these words also sound like the sort of thing a lot of people might be saying, almost a [cliché](#). “We,” all of us, are wearily dealing with living in the post-9/11 world.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 8:** “given the times we live in.”
- **Line 19:** “It's a sign of the times we live in.”

ENJAMBMENT

In this poem's flexible [free verse](#), [enjambments](#) help to create rhythm, to set the speaker's tone, and to draw attention to important ideas. A good example turns up early in the poem in lines 5-7, where the speaker considers being “offended” at the way the border agent is treating them, but ultimately decides they just don't have the energy:

but in the end, you **decide**
it makes as much **sense**
as anything else,

These line breaks split the speaker's sentence up into measured, even parts—a choice that suggests they're *holding back* a little. In these choppy but measured lines, readers might hear the speaker burying their anger for the sake of staying polite and getting through this interaction without trouble.

In lines 9-10, an enjambment frames an important [metaphor](#):

You shrink to the **size**
of the book in his hand.

By breaking the line here, Dharker gives space to two big ideas. First comes the idea of *shrinking*—feeling diminished by the agent's racism and Islamophobia. Then comes the idea of becoming the passport—feeling as if all you are to this agent is a “suspicious” nationality. Separating these related ideas out, Dharker invites readers to linger on both and consider how they connect.

The enjambment in lines 37-38 similarly lends some drama to a big image:

Half your face splits away,
drifts on to the page of a **newspaper**
that's dated today.

Here, again, an enjambment means that a crucial image gets a line to itself. The idea that the newspaper is “dated today” connects back to the speaker's weary refrain about the “times we live in,” stressing the idea that the agent's prejudice is part of a big contemporary problem. The enjambment introduces these words with a little flourish, stressing their significance.

Where Enjambment appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** “He / looks”
- **Lines 2-3:** “starts / reading”
- **Lines 5-6:** “decide / it”
- **Lines 6-7:** “sense / as”
- **Lines 9-10:** “size / of”
- **Lines 14-15:** “recently / to”
- **Lines 16-17:** “same / as”
- **Lines 37-38:** “newspaper / that's”

ASSONANCE

Intensely musical [assonance](#) gives this poem notes of humor and sadness, as well as emphasizing notable lines. The poem's repeated sigh over the “times we live in” in lines 8 and 19, for instance, uses two different flavors of assonance:

given the times we **live in**.
[...]
It's a sign of the times we live in.

In the first instance, /ih/ assonance (supported by [consonance](#)) is part of an [internal rhyme](#) between “given” and “live in,” adding a little extra punch to the first appearance of the line that gives the poem its title. The second time these words appear, long /eye/ assonance highlights the “sign of the times,” similarly

emphasizing the words.

When the speaker gets so angry with the border agent and his prejudiced suspicions that they “really have to laugh,” the poem’s assonant music takes off. Laughing so they don’t cry (or shout), the speaker uses sing-song sounds as they indulge in a little fantasy about what would have had to happen to them on the airplane to make them no longer resemble their passport photograph:

While you were flying,
up in the air
they changed your chin
and redid your hair.
They scrubbed out your mouth
and rubbed out your eyes.
They made you over completely.

The hard /eye/ of “while you were flying” and the softer /ih/ of “chin” and “redid, alongside a tumble of rhyme (*air / hair, scrubbed out / rubbed out*), make these lines musical. This passage sounds outright *jaunty*—an [ironic](#), darkly comical effect, considering how angry the speaker is as they make this not-so-funny joke.

In the next-to-last stanza, the speaker frames the poem’s climax with even more assonance:

Half your face splits away,
drifts on to the page of a newspaper
that’s dated today.

The echoing /ay/ sound here makes the speaker’s voice sound intense and concentrated, shining a spotlight on the closing image of the speaker’s broken, drifting face.

Where Assonance appears in the poem:

- **Line 8:** “given,” “live in”
- **Line 11:** “mind”
- **Line 12:** “eye”
- **Line 19:** “sign,” “times”
- **Line 24:** “While,” “flying”
- **Line 26:** “chin”
- **Line 27:** “redid”
- **Line 28:** “scrubbed”
- **Line 29:** “rubbed,” “eyes”
- **Line 31:** “surprise”
- **Line 32:** “match,” “photograph”
- **Line 33:** “that”
- **Line 36:** “face,” “away”
- **Line 37:** “page,” “newspaper”
- **Line 38:** “dated today”

PARALLELISM

Anaphora and broader [parallelism](#) helps to create the poem’s tension. In the first two stanzas, for instance, the speaker’s [anaphora](#) on “you” keeps insisting that readers step into the second-person role, putting themselves in the speaker’s uncomfortable shoes:

You hand over your passport. He
looks at your face and starts
reading you backwards from the last page.
You could be offended,
[...]
You shrink to the size
of the book in his hand.
You can see his mind working:

Besides keeping the focus on the word “you,” this anaphora feels immediate, following along with this stand-off moment by moment.

Later in the poem, the speaker has a dark chuckle over the border agent’s long, slow look at their passport photo, imagining everything that would have had to happen on the airplane in order for them to look different from their picture. Here, parallelism gives momentum and force to their frustration:

they changed your chin
and redid your hair.
They scrubbed out your mouth
and rubbed out your eyes.
They made you over completely.

The echoing sentence structure here feels brisk and lively, supporting a mood of dark and angry humor. After a certain point, the snappy rhythm here helps to suggest, it’s just impossible to take a self-important little man seriously.

Where Parallelism appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** “You”
- **Line 4:** “You”
- **Line 9:** “You”
- **Line 11:** “You”
- **Line 26:** “they”
- **Line 27:** “and”
- **Line 28:** “They”
- **Line 29:** “and”
- **Line 30:** “They”



VOCABULARY

The times we live in (Line 8, Line 19) - An [allusion](#) to the circumstances in the years around this poem's first appearance. Dharker published this poem in 2006, when (in the wake of the terrorist group Al-Qaeda's attacks on the U.S. on September 11, 2001) the western world saw a terrible burst of Islamophobia.

The book (Lines 9-10) - That is, the speaker's passport.

It contains a Z (Lines 12-13) - This line suggests that the border agent is suspicious of the speaker's name because it sounds "foreign": Z is a rare letter in English names. (The line also hints that this experience might be Imtiaz Dharker's own.)

Just moved house (Line 13) - That is, just had a change of address, moved from one house to another.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"These are the times we live in (I)" is the first poem in Imtiaz Dharker's three-poem sequence of the same title. Each of these poems deals with Islamophobia in the early 21st century. In this opening piece, a speaker meets with rude suspicion from a border agent while traveling—an experience that painfully reflects the "times we live in."

The poem is written in [free verse](#). That means that it doesn't use a regular [rhyme scheme](#) or [meter](#) but rather unfolds in an organic, loosely structured way. Dharker uses this form's flexibility to create drama—for instance, by using changing stanza lengths to highlight moments of suspense.

The poem uses seven stanzas, ranging from just one to ten lines long. The movement from longer to shorter stanzas often marks moments of particular intensity. When the border control officer takes a long look at the speaker's passport photo, for instance, he does so over just three lines (lines 20-22, "In front of you [...] looks at you suspiciously"). Depicting this moment in such a small, concentrated space, Dharker suggests the tense silence that rises up as this nasty man gives the speaker a long stare.

Dharker's use of the second person here (that is, her choice to frame the poem as something that is happening to "you") makes the story feel particularly immediate. This poem seems likely to be at least semi-autobiographical, considering the "Z" in both the protagonist's and the author's names. But Dharker asks the reader to step into her shoes, sharing an uncomfortable first-hand experience of confronting xenophobia and Islamophobia at a border. The reader is invited to imagine their way into the anger, the sorrow, and the bleak humor of getting profiled.

METER

There's no [meter](#) in this [free verse](#) poem. Rather than sticking to a steady beat, Dharker uses changing line lengths and stanza shapes to give the poem its rhythm.

For instance, in the third stanza, where the border officer looks suspiciously at the speaker's passport photograph, the lines have a cool, deliberate pace:

In front of you,
he flicks to the photograph,
and looks at you suspiciously.

These slow, careful [end-stopped](#) lines feel fittingly steady and unhurried. This man has no problem giving the speaker an insulting once-over right "in front of [them]," and the way Dharker breaks down this sentence—one clause at a time, a line for each—suggests just how insultingly *thorough* he's being as he profiles the speaker, treating them like a potential criminal simply because they come from a predominantly Muslim country.

Toward the end of the poem in lines 37-38, meanwhile, an [enjambment](#) supports the poem's tone, stressing the speaker's sorrow and frustration:

Half your face splits away,
drifts on to the page of a newspaper
that's dated today.

By enjambling the line "a newspaper / that's dated today," the speaker draws special attention to the words "dated today"—words that hearken back to the poem's title and its repeated line about the "times we live in." Those times, this speaker knows all too well, are Islamophobic ones.

RHYME SCHEME

While there's no regular [rhyme scheme](#) in this poem, there is plenty of rhyme. Toward the end of the poem, when the speaker is rolling her eyes over the border officer's suspicion of her photograph, flashes of rhyme highlight the dark comedy of the moment—and the speaker's real pain. Take this passage from lines 28-35, for instance:

They scrubbed out your mouth
and rubbed out your eyes.
They made you over completely.
And all that's left is his look of surprise,
because you don't match your photograph.
Even that is coming apart.
The pieces are there
but they missed out your heart.

The [internal rhyme](#) of *scrubbed out* / *rubbed out* feels aggressive,

capturing the energy of this vigorous erasure. The [end rhymes](#) between *eyes / surprise* and *apart / heart*, meanwhile, slow this passage down and ask speakers to pay special attention to what's really at stake here. The Islamophobic border agent completely overlooks the speaker's "heart" (their sincere sense of self and their true feelings).



SPEAKER

This poem is written in the second person: its speaker describes events happening to "you," while still seeming to recount their own experience. This choice invites readers to step into the speaker's shoes as they wait patiently at border control, being not-so-subtly humiliated and dehumanized by a nasty little man behind a desk.

One of the things that readers can gather about this speaker's identity—in spite of the fact that it's never stated outright in the poem—is that they likely have a lot in common with Imtiaz Dharker. The poem drops a hint about this when it observes that the name on the speaker's passport has a Z in it. But the whole scenario here also makes it clear that the poem's protagonist is, like the poet, a person born in a Muslim-majority country (like Dharker's native Pakistan).

The speaker doesn't need to spell out that the border agent is thinking Islamophobic, discriminatory thoughts as he slowly examines their passport photograph. The poem's weary [allusions](#) to the "times we live in" make it clear that this poem is dealing with the way the western world got crueler to Muslim (or stereotypically "Muslim-looking") people in the early 21st century, when this poem was published.

The speaker is clearly furious and sad about the way the border agent treats them. But they can also see the dark humor in it all. They "have to laugh" when the agent suspiciously eyes their passport photo and launch into a sarcastic fantasy about everything that would have to have happened on the airplane for them to no longer look like their picture. This dark humor comes across as a coping mechanism, a way to deal with an experience that erodes the speaker's sense of self, of belonging, and of safety.



SETTING

The poem is set at border control in an airport—a tense and highly political setting. Importantly, the speaker doesn't specify *which* border control in *which* country. Readers familiar with Imtiaz Dharker's background as a Pakistani immigrant to the UK might imagine that this poem draws on her personal experience of coming home after a visit to family abroad. But by refusing to specify exactly where its events are happening, the poem also makes it clear that the racism this poem's speaker faces isn't confined to any one country.

The events of this poem are, however, connected to a particular *time*—the "times we live in." Dharker published this poem in 2006, and it clearly responds to the dreadful world events of the early 21st century: the September 11 attacks in 2001, the U.S. invasion of Iraq in 2003, and the discrimination against Muslim people (and, stereotypically, brown-skinned people in general) that burgeoned in the wake of these tragedies. The experience Dharker describes is recognizably part of the post-9/11 world, in which getting through airport security and border control became a fraught and frequently racist experience.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

Imtiaz Dharker is a British poet who was born in Lahore, the capital of Pakistan, in 1954. She grew up primarily in Glasgow, Scotland, where her family moved when she was a year old. Dharker studied at the University of Glasgow, graduating with an M.A. in English Literature and Philosophy. She has won many awards for her poetry, including a 2011 Cholmondeley Prize and a 2014 Queen's Gold Medal, and serves as a member of the Royal Society of Literature. Alongside her writing, Dharker works as an artist and a documentarian.

Dharker has published numerous books of verse, including the 2006 *The Terrorist at my Table*, in which this poem was first collected. Her poems often deal with questions of identity, cultural displacement, and community. This collection in particular examines life as an immigrant with roots in a Muslim country living in the west in the early 21st century. "These are the times we live in (I)" is, as its title suggests, the first in a sequence of poems dealing with this theme.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Dharker published "These are the times we live in"—the first of a three-poem sequence by the same title—in 2006, not long after the September 11, 2001 attacks on the United States. In these attacks, members of the Islamist terrorist group Al-Qaeda hijacked passenger airplanes and used them to destroy buildings, razing New York's World Trade Center and a part of the Pentagon. Thousands of people died. The U.S. was deeply shaken by an unprecedented attack on its own terrain and civilians.

Soon thereafter, George W. Bush, then president of the United States, used these attacks as an excuse to mount the 2003 U.S. invasion of Iraq. This was the beginning of a war that many protested: Iraq had no provable involvement in the September 11 attacks, and many of the government's justifications for this war—notably the claim that Iraq had nuclear weapons—were false.

In the wake of these events, Islamophobia and racism

burgeoned in the western world. Particularly at borders and in airports, Muslims (and, more generally, people who looked, to the racist observer, like the stereotypical *idea* of a Muslim) faced discriminatory scrutiny and suspicion not just from border agents but also from their fellow citizens.

- [The Poem Aloud](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ndmJpsCinVY) — Listen to a reading of the poem. (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ndmJpsCinVY>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER IMTIAZ DHARKER POEMS

- [A century later](#)
- [Blessing](#)
- [Living Space](#)
- [Tissue](#)



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [A Short Biography](#) — Learn more about Dharker through her publisher, Bloodaxe Books. (<https://www.bloodaxebooks.com/ecs/category/imtiaz-dharker>)
- [A Celebration of Dharker](#) — Read an article praising Dharker's work, written after she won the Queen's Gold Medal for Poetry. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2014/dec/17/imtiaz-dharker-queens-gold-medal-poetry>)
- [Dharker's Website](#) — Visit Dharker's personal website to learn more about her poetry and other creative projects. (<http://www.imtiazdharker.com/>)



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